

It's been a mixed year for Gurindervir Singh. At the Federation Cup, the sprinter broke the 100 metre national record twice: 10.17 seconds in the semi-final, 10.09 seconds in the final. But at the Commonwealth Games, he failed to reach the semi-final. Call it performance pressure as the fastest man in India. But he is unperturbed—he knows his best is yet to come.

Singh is a late-bloomer of sorts, taking to sprinting after being dazzled by Usain Bolt's prowess at the 2008 Beijing Olympics. His father, Kamaljeet, a former volleyball player, was his first coach, who introduced him to the life of an athlete. Even as a junior in 2017, he had gone sub-11 seconds and regularly climbed the domestic podium. But he was laid low by a stomach condition that kept him from optimal training. "It got so bad my father asked me to give up on running and figure something else to do," says the Reliance Foundation athlete.

The recovery was tedious, but Singh clinched a gold in 10.32 seconds at the Indian Championships in 2024. The rebuilding process began under coach James Hillier. "It took some time to understand the nuances of training in a new system and with a new coach," he says. "There were injuries and days when the body wasn't responding. But I kept at it and what I've achieved this year is the result of my persistence." His training mates include Animesh Kujur, the 200m national record holder, and former 100m national record holders, Manikanta Hoblidhar and Amlan Borgohain.

The national record has done wonders for his confidence. It's the sixth-fastest timing in Asia this year and makes him a solid podium contender in athletics where India will have other medal hopefuls in long jumpers Ancy Sojan and Murali Sreeshankar, and long distance runner, Gulveer Singh. Setting the disappointment of Commonwealth Games aside, Singh wants to trust the training he's put in over the last year as he gears up for the Asian Games. "There's no point talking about targets. I want to go there and show how it's done," he says. ■

—Shail Desai

A BOLT OF LIGHTNING

GURINDERVIR SINGH, 25

Sport: ***ATHLETICS***

Discipline: **100m sprint**

Claim to fame

Current 100 metre national record holder